

Aircraft Maintenance Shop Takeover — Due Diligence Checklist

Florida-panhandle A&P/IA shop (suspected **Oyster Aviation @ KAAF**) · "What to look for" before committing

Prepared for Arachnid Systems | Ben | 2026-05-30 | Internal / exploratory

Frame this correctly. This is **not a sale** — the owner wants an A&P/IA to **take over** a turnkey shop ("not selling, not hiring, just can't do it anymore"). Evaluate it as a low-cost **capability & test-bed** play for ATLAS — a captive hangar, real aircraft, and a certification on-ramp — **not** as an MRO business acquisition. The single gating requirement is supplying a certificated A&P/IA to operate it.

Confirm identity first. The Reddit post says only "Florida panhandle" — it does **not** name Oyster Aviation or KAAF. Verify which shop and field this actually is before anything else; the whole airfield thesis depends on it.

1. Deal structure & terms

✓	What to look for	Why it matters
☐	Exactly what "take over" means — money, no money, or lease assignment + equipment handoff?	Determines whether this is ~free or a real purchase.
☐	Asset vs. equity transfer; what entity / liabilities (if any) come with it	Avoid inheriting debts, tax, or legal exposure.
☐	Whether the owner will stay on (transition / earnout / consulting)	Key-person continuity — see §6.
☐	Any exclusivity; how many other parties he's talking to	Sets urgency and negotiating leverage.

2. Certifications & regulatory (the real prize)

✓	What to look for	Why it matters
☐	Which certificates exist: independent A&P/IA individuals vs. a Part 145 repair station	A&P/IA is personal to the mechanic; a 145 cert is an asset. Very different value.
☐	Do certificates / authority transfer on ownership change, or must we re-credential?	A&P/IA does NOT transfer with a building — you need your own certificated person.
☐	Ratings / limitations, ops specs, any open FAA findings or enforcement history	Hidden compliance liabilities.
☐	Path to add an autonomous-inspection workflow under that authority	The strategic reason to care — ATLAS sign-off route.

3. The hangar & airport lease

✓	What to look for	Why it matters
☐	Lease term, rent, renewal options, and transferability / assignment rights	You inherit a leasehold, not land — county can block transfer.
☐	Landlord = Franklin County? FAA grant-assurance obligations on the field	Restricts permitted uses, subleasing, exclusive-rights deals.
☐	Hangar condition, true 5-plane capacity, power / utilities, security	Fit for ATLAS robotics + ITAR / air-gapped work? Likely needs upgrades.

✓	What to look for	Why it matters
☐	Field suitability: non-towered, 3× 5,000+ ft runways, near-zero based traffic (KAAF)	The actual strategic asset — quiet flight-test / UAS environment.

4. Equipment, parts & physical assets

✓	What to look for	Why it matters
☐	Itemized equipment list + condition + calibration certs (“all except hand tools”)	Confirm what conveys; calibration drives airworthiness sign-offs.
☐	Parts-room inventory value & traceability (“partially stocked”)	Untraceable / SUP parts are a liability, not an asset.
☐	Tooling owned vs. leased; software / maintenance-tracking licenses	Hidden recurring costs or non-transferable licenses.
☐	Environmental / hazmat: fuel, solvents, oils, disposal records	Contamination liability can dwarf the deal value.

5. Financials & the existing book

✓	What to look for	Why it matters
☐	The “planes in the queue” — how many, contracted vs. verbal, \$ value	Immediate-revenue claim — verify it's real and will stay.
☐	Trailing revenue, margin, and the “low fixed costs” figure (rent, utilities, insurance)	Baseline operating economics.
☐	Customer concentration & whether clients follow the new operator	Goodwill may walk with the owner.
☐	Insurance: hangar-keepers, product / completed-ops liability, premiums	MRO liability is significant; sets carrying cost.

6. People & key-person risk [HIGHEST RISK]

✓	What to look for	Why it matters
☐	Who currently holds the A&P/IA — owner only? Any staff staying?	“Can't do it anymore” = the capability may leave with him.
☐	Can Arachnid supply / hire a certificated A&P/IA to run it? At what cost?	The gating constraint — no IA, no shop.
☐	Retention / transition terms for the owner (training, customer intros)	Protects continuity and goodwill.
☐	Local A&P labor availability (national shortage; ~1/3 AMT seats unfilled)	Rural panhandle hiring may be hard.

7. Strategic fit with ATLAS / Arachnid

✓	What to look for	Why it matters
☐	Realistic bridge from piston-GA work → ATLAS's fighter / transport / widebody targets	Cessna / Piper ≠ defense fleet; validation overlap is partial.
☐	Can the site support ITAR / air-gapped / secured work, or stay commercial-only?	Open public field conflicts with defense posture.
☐	Value of captive aircraft access + labeled defect data for model training	Core upside — quantify it.
☐	Management bandwidth: who runs a services business without distracting R&D?	Mission-drift risk vs. tiny financial weight.

Go / No-Go — the decisive test

PROCEED only if ALL are true:

- Identity & terms confirmed, and total cost (incl. lease + an A&P/IA hire) is low.
- Lease is transferable and permits Arachnid's intended use.
- We can secure a certificated A&P/IA operator.
- There is a credible path from this shop to **accelerating ATLAS validation / certification** vs. our current partner-access model.

WALK AWAY if: the work stays piston-GA with no bridge to defense / commercial platforms • the IA capability can't be secured • the lease is non-transferable • or it becomes a management distraction relative to its financial weight.

Sources & full analysis: oyster-aviation-kaaf-acquisition-analysis.md, market-research-landscape.md, EXEC-SUMMARY-one-pager.md. Caveats: shop identity (Oyster / KAAF) is inferred, not confirmed; ATLAS specs / partners drawn from public website; market figures from third-party research vendors (directional). For internal use.